



Beyond the Witch-Hunt of Zero-Tolerance Policies: A Response to ‘GenAI and Academic Writing’ (Jandrić 2026)

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Introduction: The Editor’s Predicament

When Jandrić (2026) describes his experiences as an editor confronting unacknowledged GenAI use in submissions to *Postdigital Science and Education*, he articulates pressing concerns. His four challenges—detection, sourcing, writing, and attitude—represent difficulties that scholarly publishers now face. His honesty about his own editorial mistakes (Park 2024) is commendable. His invocation of *episteme* (true justified belief) over *doxa* (common opinion) as the goal of scholarly publishing is a sound principle.

However, the zero-tolerance policy and blacklist that Jandrić proposes do not follow logically from his own diagnosis. If detection is impossible, as he acknowledges, a blacklist is unenforceable. If ‘the border between co-writing and word processing is blurring’ (Jandrić 2026: 376), a blacklist is unjust. If the goal is to educate authors, change unethical behavioural patterns, and improve scholarly practice, a ban is counterproductive. Scholarly publishing has long relied on distributed production systems encompassing editors, copyeditors, software, databases, and infrastructures. Generative AI represents a continuation and expansion of this established condition rather than a fundamental transformation of it.

This paper examines these inconsistencies and offers an alternative framework grounded in communication theory, copyright laws, and empirical evidence about research practices. It engages directly with Jandrić’s (2026) proposed challenges and solutions, addressing each one of his key arguments in turn, and presenting a counter-proposal.

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The Question of Criteria and AI in the Loop Policies

The emergence of AI systems—functioning as digital ‘co-workers’—offers significant potential for publishers, educators, researchers, and all stakeholders in academic writing. Large language models can be calibrated for the design, evaluation, and improvement of scholarly manuscripts, as well as for the verification of cited resources. Major publishers are already deploying such systems at scale. Springer Nature, for instance, has integrated nearly 60 AI tools across its workflows, supporting manuscript screening, editorial evaluation, and research integrity checks for over 1.5 million papers in 2025 alone (Springer Nature 2026a). Similarly, Wiley has implemented an AI-powered transfer system that suggests suitable journals and preserves peer review reports, enabling expert feedback to follow manuscripts between journals and streamlining the publication process (Wiley 2025). These developments illustrate how AI is moving from experimental prototypes to operational infrastructure, reshaping the landscape of academic publishing. This requires careful consideration of detection, accountability, writing standards, and author/editors’ attitudes.

These topics are addressed here through the counter-proposals presented in this paper, drawing on O’Driscoll and McGreal’s (2026) distinction between roles in the scholarly communication process, which helps clarify how responsibility and accountability may be distributed in AI-assisted writing. The Principal is the human author, who retains full responsibility for the content and for all post-publication communications. The Designer is the AI tool, deployed to shape register and style, perform editing, manage references, and identify relevant online resources. The Disseminator is the publisher or distribution channel, which functions as an intermediary between the author and the intended audience.

Detection: Technical and Legal Impossibility

The Infeasibility of Reliable Detection

Jandrić (2026) understands that unacknowledged GenAI co-writing cannot be reliably detected or proven with current technology. Empirical research supports this position. Liang et al. (2023) demonstrated that GPT detectors are biased against non-native English writers, producing false positives that disproportionately affect scholars from linguistic backgrounds other than English. Weber-Wulff et al. (2023) assessed fourteen detection tools and found them neither accurate nor dependable. Sadasivan et al. (2024) showed that AI-generated text can be easily edited to evade detection with trivial modifications.

If detection is technically impossible, policies based on punishment for undetected violations are unenforceable. Blacklists constructed on the basis of editorial ‘hunches’—even well-developed ones—resemble what can be characterised as the star-chamber system of the Middle Ages: secretive, arbitrary, and lacking procedural justice.

The Integration of AI into Writing Environments

The practical reality of contemporary writing further undermines zero-tolerance approaches. Standard word processing platforms—including Microsoft 365, which many academic authors use—now have AI functions (Editor, Copilot, GPT for MS Word) integrated at the deepest level. These tools provide suggestions for sentence restructuring, grammar correction, and stylistic refinement upon user request. The default writing environment of 2026 is one in which AI assistance is always there, offering and engaging the writer with options.

In this context, requiring authors to declare every instance of AI-assisted editing is neither practical nor meaningful. Springer Nature's (2026b) guidelines that 'AI-assisted copy editing need not be declared when used only to improve readability, grammar, or formatting' (quoted in Jandrić 2026: 379) are unenforceable precisely because the distinction between 'formatting' and 'generating' is, as Jandrić (2026: 376) concedes, 'blurring'. If the line cannot be reliably distinguished, policies that depend on such distinctions cannot be consistently applied.

Copyright Law: AI as Tool, Not Author

Legal frameworks and cases in Europe (Lentner 2026; Čemalović 2026) and the USA reinforce the argument that AI should be treated as a tool rather than an author or co-author. In *Thaler v. Perlmutter* (2025), the United States Court of Appeals affirmed that AI-generated works lack copyright protection because copyright requires human authorship. The United States Copyright Office (2023:16, 191) states: 'In the Office's view, it is well-established that copyright can protect only material that is the product of human creativity. Most fundamentally, the term "author," which is used in both the Constitution and the Copyright Act, excludes non-humans'.

Asking authors to 'acknowledge' GenAI as a co-author is a category error. The AI serves as a sophisticated tool—like a keyboard, a reference manager, statistical or thematic analysis software—whose outputs the human user selects, edits, and assumes responsibility for (Craig and Kerr 2021). The boundaries need to be clear on what is human and what is machine. Giving personhood traits to AI as co-author could be dangerous (Center for Humane Technology 2026).

Counter-proposal: The roles need to be clear. AI software works as a facilitator or designer tool to speed up the process and enhance performance. It should do what it promises correctly. Authors must acknowledge their use of specific tools (so others can use them too if they work well) at the end of their papers and confirm that they have reviewed the paper and accept full responsibility for the content.

Accountability: Human Principals Remain Responsible

The Irreducible Human Principal

Regardless of how much of the designer/facilitator function is delegated to AI, accountability must remain with a human principal (O'Driscoll and McGreal 2026).

This conclusion is supported by several considerations. First, only humans can be held legally responsible for the truthfulness of claims. Second, only humans can provide follow-up clarification or correction of published work. Third, the scholarly community requires identifiable points of accountability for the integrity of the knowledge base. Finally, AI has yet not surpassed human creativity in writing, and its outputs remain relatively easy for an editor to detect (Jandrić 2026; Mank 2025).

Judith E. Mank (2025), Editor-in-Chief of *Evolution Letters*, offers a perspective that differs somewhat from Jandrić's (2026). She describes the ongoing effort to balance the responsible use of AI with professional ethics as both necessary and intellectually engaging. While supporting the view that AI is not yet capable of independently producing a publishable scientific paper (AI flop) for the journal, Mank (2025: 381) concludes that 'banning the use of LLMs and GenAI' is 'neither reasonable nor enforceable'.

Questionable Research Practices: A Pre-existing Problem

Jandrić (2026) treats fabricated references as a novel problem introduced by GenAI. However, empirical research demonstrates that questionable research practices pre-date LLMs and remain widespread. Kepes et al. (2022) show that such practices—including *post hoc* sample size manipulation, selective exclusion of unsupported hypotheses, and HARKing (Hypothesising After the Results are Known)—are paradoxically more prevalent in prestigious journals than in their lower-impact counterparts. Similarly, Retraction Watch (2025) documented hundreds of cases involving fabricated references and other forms of misconduct long before the emergence of ChatGPT.

Rather than creating a new category of misconduct, GenAI appears to amplify an existing one. The appropriate response, therefore, is not to ban AI from referencing but to address the underlying problems of research integrity, editorial capacity, and institutional support for rigorous scholarship. AI tools will likely improve and resolve these issues, if scholars work in the same direction. At present, AI tools often require human calibration and ongoing exposure to high-quality data in order to function effectively. In this context, Mank (2025) observes that AI use has rapidly become embedded in research and writing practices, enhancing its efficiency:

.... tools have replaced simple web searches as the best route to find scripts for specific tasks. When writing, many people I spoke with use LLMs to find a specific turn of phrase, shave words off applications with strict limits, or generate short texts on specific topics that they then edit. For others, LLMs are remarkably effective at helping reduce the cognitive burden of writing in a language with which they are less comfortable. This latter use is perhaps the most promising application of LLMs as long as English remains the primary medium of scientific discussion. (Mank 2025: 381)

Accountability is not only about data and creative concepts synthesis but also includes the presentation of data and the design of communication strategies for

specific venues such as conferences, journals, or scientific blogs. In these areas, AI has the potential to enhance both the speed and the quality of stylistic expression, including tone and register, even for native English speakers. AI agents, if designed appropriately, can also enhance writing skills or function as a continuously updated pool of resources—under the supervision of an experienced academic.

Counter-proposal: As outlined in the ‘Introduction’, each role in the scholarly communication process requires transparency for accountability.

Principal role: The named human author(s) determine core meanings, arguments, and research findings, and stand by the work they submit. They can name the tools they used for research, referencing, summarization, or designing a paper to support dissemination of the scientific material and enable others to follow suit. Their goal is to disseminate scientific research and keep up with innovative research technologies.

Designer role: A collaboration between the human author(s) and GenAI to shape form, referencing, structure, and wording. The human preserves their voice and critically evaluates all AI output. AI services need to deliver what they have been promising, provide accurate information, and be accountable for this. Their goal is to help researchers to do scientifically sound research and evaluate it.

Disseminator role: The chain including human authors (typing/issuing text), the GenAI interface (checking sources), the Internet service provider (transmitting the text), and the publisher (evaluating and disseminating the final work). Publishers such as Springer Nature and Wiley use AI tools and agents and keep up with training on innovative technologies. The goal is to publish academically sound research findings and arguments.

This tripartite model clarifies responsibilities and accountability: authors remain the ethical and intellectual agents of record; AI systems are cast as supportive instruments for form, access, and curation rather than as autonomous authors; and publishers assume the role of brokers for dissemination, audience targeting, and platform governance. By separating authorship, stylistic/design functions, and dissemination, the framework promotes transparency about the provenance of content, facilitates responsible use of AI in scholarly workflows, and enables publishers to implement context-appropriate policies on attribution, review, and access.

Writing: Aesthetic Criteria and Epistemic Judgment

The Subjectivity of Aesthetic Preferences

Jandrić (2026: 3) writes that he finds GenAI writing ‘aesthetically unpleasant—sterile and boring, like those great-looking industrially grown tomatoes with no taste or smell’. While this aesthetic judgment is personally sincere, it does not constitute a valid epistemological criterion for editorial decision-making. A considerable proportion of human-written academic prose is also characterised by repetition, circular argumentation, and formulaic grammatical expression. The question of epistemic merit—whether a paper contributes verifiable, justified knowledge—is distinct from questions of stylistic flair or writerly voice.

It is important to acknowledge that people's assessments of AI outputs are subject to bias. Aesthetic judgments about AI-generated content are demonstrably unreliable and heavily influenced by ex post facto knowledge of authorship, not by intrinsic properties of the work itself. An informal social media anecdote (Zhang 2026) illustrates a telling social experiment in which a user posted an actual Claude Monet painting—from his celebrated Water Lilies series—falsely labelling it as AI-generated. Critics responded with confident, detailed negative assessments. When the deception was revealed, many of these critics deleted their replies. This experiment empirically demonstrates that when people believe a work is AI-generated, they systematically perceive flaws that are not objectively present.

This finding aligns with peer-reviewed research; a 2024 study published in *Nature* by Grassini and Koivisto found that:

Participants were unable to consistently distinguish between human and AI-created images. Furthermore, despite generally preferring the AI-generated artworks over human-made ones, the participants displayed a negative bias against AI-generated artworks when subjective perception of source attribution was considered, thus rating as less preferable the artworks perceived more as AI-generated, independently on their true source. (Grassini and Koivisto 2024: 1)

In other words, the bias against AI is a product of labelling, not observable quality. Furthermore, the famous Kruger et al. (2004) study on 'the effort heuristic' shows that people value art more simply because they believe it took more time and effort to create—a heuristic that has no logical bearing on the final work's epistemic or artistic merit.

Consequently, aesthetic standards in academic publishing are not culturally neutral. Scholars for whom English is an additional language may face systematic disadvantage when rhetorical style—rather than epistemic substance—is treated as a criterion for publication. For such researchers, AI tools may serve as legitimate aids in navigating the stylistic conventions of Anglophone journals without compromising the epistemic integrity of their work. Varoufakis (2026) discusses democratic debate and the concept *isegoria*, which distinguishes between the substance of an argument and its rhetorical formulation—a distinction that aligns with treating AI as a designer while retaining human accountability for human agency. He explains:

..... isegoria meant the exact opposite of today's free speech, which they would dismiss as the abstract right to shout into the void. To the Athenians, it meant the right to have your views judged seriously, on their merits, independently of who you are or indeed how well you phrase them (Varoufakis 2026: Para 7).

Counter-proposal: Editors who claim to detect AI use based on 'hunch' are not exercising expertise; rather, they may be enacting bias. Consequently, publishers, in their role as disseminators, should focus on the quality of arguments, research methods, and findings, rather than on word processing, provided that it is clearly and effectively formulated with AI assistance as designer (beforementioned) under the author supervision. They may benefit from investing more time in developing expertise in

the use of specific AI agents to assess the quality of arguments, resources and sound research as demonstrated by organisations such as Wiley and Springer Nature.

Attitude: Education and Progressive Regulation

The Limitations of Punitive Approaches

In most fields and in academic contexts, fear-based approaches have limited reach because they are procedurally unjust. They create silence rather than transparency, drive problematic behaviour underground rather than transforming it, and disproportionately affect those who are confused or anxious rather than those who are deliberately deceitful. Jandrić (2026: 7) himself reports that ‘an increasing number of authors either plead ignorance or genuinely believe that their practice is unproblematic’. Their use of GenAI may very well be unproblematic.

Education as a Strategy for Cultural Change

Academic publishing is about creating expert communities that could spread the latest ideas, inform practice and policy, support innovation, and contribute to public understanding. Thoughtfully, Jandrić (2026) invokes a Freirean critical pedagogy of trust (Jandrić 2018a, b) and expresses a desire ‘to raise critical consciousness about co-writing with GenAI’ and ‘to reach those good people who may have gone astray for various reasons such as lack of knowledge or time’ (Jandrić 2026: 12). This educational goal is laudable. However, a pedagogy of trust cannot be built on a foundation of blacklists. Trust is not the opposite of punishment; it is the opposite of systematic suspicion. The bases of building communities for shared wisdom could benefit from AI in the loop policies (Pentland 2025).

Education works best when we create a shared narrative through influence and social contagion (Christakis 2020; Pentland 2015, 2025). Good practices spread when they are modelled, celebrated, and discussed. Jandrić’s own examples of positive human-AI collaboration—Palalas et al. 2025; Escaño 2024—should be widely disseminated in editorial offices, doctoral seminars, and faculty meetings. These exemplar papers demonstrate that transparent, ethical, epistemically sound AI-assisted scholarship is possible. Especially following the Covid-19 pandemic, science and scientists have faced attacks on social media, reduced funding, and increased mistrust from policymakers (Christakis 2020).

Conclusion: Towards an AI in the Loop Scholarship

Jandrić (2026: 13) ends his paper with an invitation: ‘If you are unsure of any aspect of GenAI use in your scholarship, ask your editor! We will discuss the matter, seek further help if needed, and produce an ethical solution’. This invitation reflects the postdigital dialogue that scholarly communities require (Jandrić et al. 2019; Forsler 2026). Yet it is directly contradicted by the zero-tolerance policy that precedes it. A publisher cannot simultaneously invite authors to ask questions about AI and announce that any unacknowledged use will be met with an immediate ban. At the end, AI usage is stigmatised as always unethical praxis no matter how it was used.

The alternative proposed here replaces zero tolerance with AI-in-the-loop policies, blacklists with disclosure, detection with workflow redesign, and the editor as compliance enforcer with the editor as educator and life-long learner that constantly reflects on improvement. AI is here to stay, and it could assist publishers and authors in being more effective if used creatively—reduce future stigma as Mank (2025) puts it. So, the ultimate question is not if you used AI or not, but how. How can authors use AI to enhance accountability, to make their voice be heard and to formulate trustworthy connections with publishers, policymakers, and the target audience? How are publishers to harness AI to check the content and merit of papers, whether they are research-based or argumentative?

Scholarly integrity depends on accountability, not authorship purity. AI literacy is now part of scholarly literacy—the dream of the AI scientist is closer than ever (Gent 2025). Future editorial systems must therefore distinguish clearly between four qualitatively distinct categories of behaviour. First, there is deception: the intentional misrepresentation of AI use to claim unearned credit. Second, there is error: honest mistakes in citation, formatting, or disclosure that arise from confusion, time pressure, or lack of training rather than from malicious intent. Third, there is assistance: the legitimate use of AI for editing, translation, or structural refinement—activities that have long been supported by grammar checkers and proofreading tools and should not trigger moral panic. Fourth, and most productively, there is collaboration: substantive engagement with AI outputs in which the human author remains fully accountable for every claim, every source, and every line of reasoning. By maintaining these distinctions, editorial policy can punish deception, correct error, permit assistance, and encourage collaboration with AI. Finally, the authors urge readers to use AI software as a cognitive mirror to evaluate the *epistēmē* (knowledge) and *doxa* (belief) underlying the arguments in both Jandrić’s (2026) paper and this response, and subsequently to exercise their human agency in critical reflection.

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Declarations

Competing interests The authors declare no competing interests.

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